COLOSSIANS · STUDY 02 OF 12

Colossians 1:9–14

Paul's Prayer for the Colossians

Christ Is All — A Study of Colossians

Small Group Bible Study Series · NASB95

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① Text	② Devotional	③ Commentary	④ Self-Study Guide
Foundation	Personal preparation	Teacher / leader preparation	Group meeting
Everyone	*All group members*	*Teacher / leader*	*Small group*

⑤ *Application closes each study and draws from all sections above.*

Time guide: about 30 minutes — Devotional 4 · Commentary 15 · Discussion 8 · Application 3.

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① BIBLICAL TEXT

Colossians 1:9–14 · New American Standard Bible (NASB95)

1:9 *For this reason also, since the day we heard of it, we have not ceased to pray for you and to ask that you may be filled with the knowledge of His will in all spiritual wisdom and understanding,*

10 *so that you will walk in a manner worthy of the Lord, to please Him in all respects, bearing fruit in every good work and increasing in the knowledge of God;*

11 *strengthened with all power, according to His glorious might, for the attaining of all steadfastness and patience; joyously*

12 *giving thanks to the Father, who has qualified us to share in the inheritance of the saints in Light.*

13 *For He rescued us from the domain of darkness, and transferred us to the kingdom of His beloved Son,*

14 *in whom we have redemption, the forgiveness of sins.*

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② DEVOTIONAL

Personal preparation · Drawn from the outline of this study

Building on a Good Foundation

> *“so that you will walk in a manner worthy of the Lord, to please Him in all respects, bearing fruit in every good work and increasing in the knowledge of God”*
>
> *— Colossians 1:10 (NASB95)*

What do you pray for when you pray for other believers? Most of our prayer lists are full of health, jobs, and travel, and those are good things to bring to God. But listen to Paul. From a prison cell he prays that believers he has never met will be filled with the knowledge of God's will, so that their lives will please the Lord in every way.

Paul's prayer is built like a house. Knowledge is the foundation. A worthy walk is the structure that rises on it. Then comes the part everyone can see: fruitful work, growing knowledge, endurance with joy, and a heart full of thanks. Nothing in this prayer is for show. God's power is given for the field and the workplace, not for the display case.

And beneath it all lies what the Father has already done. He qualified us, rescued us from the domain of darkness, transferred us into the kingdom of His beloved Son, and gave us redemption, the forgiveness of sins. We do not walk worthy in order to be accepted. We walk worthy because we already are.

For reflection

1. If God answered every prayer you prayed for others last week, how would their spiritual lives be different?
2. Where do you most need God's power for "steadfastness and patience," with circumstances or with people?
3. Which of the Father's gifts in verses 12–14 moves you most to thanksgiving today?

Pray for someone this week the way Paul prayed, and then, like Paul, help answer your own prayer.

③ COMMENTARY

Teacher preparation resource · Full text organized under outline headings

> **The passage teaches:** Paul prays that believers will be filled with the knowledge of God's will so that they may walk worthy of the Lord, and that worthy walk shows itself in fruitful work, growing knowledge, power to endure with joy, and thanksgiving for the Father who qualified, rescued, transferred, and redeemed them.

Outline

I. The Foundation: Knowledge (1:9)
- A. A Prayer That Never Stopped
- B. Three Words for One Need
- C. Paul Answers His Own Prayer

II. The Superstructure: A Worthy Walk (1:10a)

III. The Outer Part: What People See (1:10b–14)
- A. Bearing Fruit in Every Good Work (1:10b)
- B. Increasing in the Knowledge of God (1:10c)
- C. Strengthened with All Power (1:11)
- D. Giving Thanks to the Father (1:12–14)

Introduction

In our last study Paul thanked God for the faith, love, and hope of the Colossians (1:3–8). Now thanksgiving turns into petition. "For this reason" (v.9) points back to everything he has just heard: they had heard "the word of truth, the gospel" (v.5), they had "understood the grace of God in truth" (v.6), and they had shown "love in the Spirit" (v.8). The reason also includes the danger just over the horizon. False teachers were offering a "deeper knowledge." Paul's answer is to pray that the Colossians would be filled with the real thing.

Paul often pictures the Christian life as a building (1 Cor. 3:9–15; Eph. 2:20–22), and that picture fits this prayer well. There is a **foundation** (knowledge), a **superstructure** (a worthy walk), and an **outer part**, the part people see (fruit, growth, endurance, and thanksgiving).

I. The Foundation: Knowledge (1:9)

A. A Prayer That Never Stopped

"Since the day we heard of it, we have not ceased to pray for you." Paul did not pray for the Colossians once and move on. They were on his heart day after day, even though he had never seen their faces (2:1).

B. Three Words for One Need

Paul asks that they "may be filled with the knowledge of His will in all spiritual wisdom and understanding." Three words work together here:

- **Knowledge** (*epignōsis*) is full, accurate, personal knowledge. The false teachers boasted of *gnōsis*; Paul prays for *epi-gnōsis*, knowledge that goes all the way in.
- **Wisdom** (*sophia*) is the skill to use that knowledge in real situations of life, including the discernment to spot error in doctrine.
- **Understanding** (*synesis*) is the ability to "bring things together," to put one truth beside another and see how they fit. Take one point of error after another and set it against the part of God's Word that exposes and refutes it. That is understanding at work.

Notice the word "filled." The Colossians did not need something added from outside the faith. They needed to be filled up with what God had already revealed. Notice also the word "spiritual." This wisdom is given by the Spirit, not achieved by human philosophy (2:8).

C. Paul Answers His Own Prayer

Where would they get this knowledge? Paul, as he so often does, becomes part of the answer to his own prayer. He prays for their knowledge, and then he writes them a letter full of it. Lenski made the point with a homely picture: if you have bread, do not simply pray for God to send bread to your hungry neighbor. Pray, and then give him bread. Our prayers for others ought to be matched by our willingness to be used in answering them.

II. The Superstructure: A Worthy Walk (1:10a)

"So that you will walk in a manner worthy of the Lord, to please Him in all respects." Knowledge is never an end in itself in Scripture. The goal of knowing God's will is doing it. "Walk" is Paul's favorite picture of daily conduct (2:6; 3:7; 4:5). To walk "worthy of the Lord" is to live in a way that fits who He is and what He has done for us.

The phrase "to please Him in all respects" uses a word (*areskeia*) that in ordinary Greek often had a bad sense: currying favor, fawning to get something. Paul reclaims it. The believer's desire is not to manipulate God into accepting him, but, already accepted, to delight Him in every area of life.

This order is vital. Paul is writing to people who are already saints (1:2), already qualified (1:12), already rescued and redeemed (1:13–14). The worthy walk is not the price of eternal life; it is the fitting response to a gift already received. Eternal life is the gift; a life that pleases the Lord is the goal of discipleship, and the Lord will one day reward it (3:24).

III. The Outer Part: What People See (1:10b–14)

Four participles describe what a worthy walk looks like from the outside: bearing fruit, increasing, being strengthened, and giving thanks.

A. Bearing Fruit in Every Good Work (1:10b)

The language of fruit runs throughout Scripture. In Genesis 1 it speaks of reproduction "after its kind." In Galatians 5:22–23 it describes the character the Spirit produces. In John 15 it is tied to abiding in Christ and to answered prayer:

> *“I am the vine, you are the branches; he who abides in Me and I in him, he bears much fruit, for apart from Me you can do nothing.”*
>
> — John 15:5 (NASB95)

In verse 6 Paul said the gospel itself is "bearing fruit." Now he prays that the believers would bear fruit too. The same word links the message to the people who receive it.

B. Increasing in the Knowledge of God (1:10c)

A tree that bears fruit keeps growing; when it stops bearing, it begins to die. Growth comes "in" or "by means of" the knowledge of God. We grow by the Word, by prayer, and by serving. Knowledge leads to obedience, and obedience leads to deeper knowledge. It is a cycle God intends to keep turning all our lives.

C. Strengthened with All Power (1:11)

"Strengthened with all power, according to His glorious might." Paul piles up the words for power: *dynamis* and *kratos*, God's ability and His might in action. And the measure of the supply is not our need but "His glorious might." What is all this power for? Not for show, but for go. It is not meant for the gymnasium, but for the field, the mine, the workplace, or wherever the task is waiting.

Specifically, the power is given "for the attaining of all steadfastness and patience; joyously."

- **Steadfastness** (*hypomonē*, literally "remaining under") is the strength to hold up under the pressures, persecutions, and temptations that come from the world around us. Trench noted that it is used chiefly of circumstances, of things.
- **Patience** (*makrothymia*, "long-tempered") is restraint toward people who provoke us. It refuses to retaliate.
- **Joyously.** God's power does not merely help us grit our teeth. It enables endurance with joy. The NASB places "joyously" with what follows, so that the joy overflows into thanksgiving.

D. Giving Thanks to the Father (1:12–14)

The final mark of the worthy walk is thanksgiving, and Paul gives four reasons for it, all of them things the Father has already done.

1. For the inheritance (1:12)

"Who has qualified us to share in the inheritance of the saints in Light." The Father is the source of every good and perfect gift (James 1:17). Here the gift is that He has "qualified" us, made us competent or fit (the same idea as 2 Cor. 3:5–6). We did not qualify ourselves. Paul speaks in the past tense: it is done. "The saints in Light" describes the present position

of believers as members of the body of Christ, enjoying the blessings that belong to the children of light now, with fuller enjoyment still to come.

2. For the rescue (1:13a)

"For He rescued us from the domain of darkness." The word "domain" (*exousia*) speaks of authority, a realm ruled by a tyrant. Satan's dominion is real, horrible, and inescapable by human effort. Only the Father could effect the rescue, and He did. The verb (*rhyomai*) means to draw someone out of danger to oneself.

3. For the transfer (1:13b)

"And transferred us to the kingdom of His beloved Son." The word for "transferred" (*methistēmi*) was used for relocating a population from one country to another. We have a new address and a new King. In Christ, the believer now belongs to the realm where the beloved Son reigns.

4. For the redemption (1:14)

"In whom we have redemption, the forgiveness of sins." Redemption (*apolytrōsis*) means release by the payment of a price. The price was not paid to Satan. God's righteousness demanded payment, God's love provided it, and God the Son paid it with His own death. The result is "the forgiveness of sins." The word for forgiveness (*aphesis*) means a sending away. Our sins have been sent away, and notice the tense: "we **have** redemption." It is a present possession, not a future hope or a reward for good behavior.

> *“In Him we have redemption through His blood, the forgiveness of our trespasses, according to the riches of His grace”*
>
> — Ephesians 1:7 (NASB95)

Conclusion

Paul's prayer gives us a model for praying for one another. He asked for more than comfort and good circumstances. He asked for knowledge that becomes wisdom, a walk that pleases the Lord, fruit, growth, power to endure with joy, and hearts full of thanks.

And he anchored all of it in what the Father has already done. We are qualified, rescued, transferred, and redeemed. The false teachers in Colossae wanted believers to strive for a status they already had. Paul wants them to enjoy it, give thanks for it, and walk worthy of the One who gave it.

Lord, thank You.

④ SELF-STUDY GUIDE

For use during the group meeting · Focused on the commentary text

Greek Word Study

Grammar and parsing: Blue Letter Bible. Sources cited selectively: STR (Strong's), THAY (Thayer's), ATR (A. T. Robertson), VINE (Vine's), MRV (Vincent's), LXX (Septuagint usage).

Verse	Greek Word (Lexical Form) / English	Strong's # / Transliteration / Form	Definition & Significance
v.9	**πληρόω** *may be filled*	**G4137** *plēroō* Aor. Pass. Subj. 2nd Pl.	**THAY:** to make full, to fill to the brim. **ATR:** passive: God is the One who fills. **Significance:** The answer to "deeper knowledge" is not addition from outside but being filled with what God has revealed.
v.9	**ἐπίγνωσις** *knowledge*	**G1922** *epignōsis* Acc. Fem. Sg.	**VINE:** full, exact knowledge; stronger than *gnōsis*. **MRV:** knowledge that lays hold of and is directed toward its object. **Significance:** Paul counters the Gnostic boast of *gnōsis* with a prayer for full, personal knowledge of God's will.
v.9	**σοφία** *wisdom*	**G4678** *sophia* Dat. Fem. Sg.	**STR:** wisdom, skill in the affairs of life. **Significance:** Wisdom applies knowledge to real situations, including discerning doctrinal error.
v.9	**σύνεσις** *understanding*	**G4907** *synesis* Dat. Fem. Sg.	**THAY:** a putting together; the critical faculty that grasps how things fit. **Significance:** Understanding sets error beside the truth of Scripture and sees why it fails.
v.10	**περιπατέω** *walk*	**G4043** *peripateō* Aor. Act. Inf.	**VINE:** to walk about; figuratively, to order one's conduct. **Significance:** Knowledge has a purpose: a daily life that fits the Lord (cf. 2:6; 3:7; 4:5).
v.10	**ἀρεσκεία** *to please*	**G699** *areskeia* Acc. Fem. Sg.	**MRV:** in classical Greek often in a bad sense, obsequiousness; here reclaimed for pleasing God. **Significance:** Believers, already accepted, aim to delight the Lord in every respect, not to earn acceptance.
v.10	**καρποφορέω** *bearing fruit*	**G2592** *karpophoreō* Pres. Act. Ptc. Nom. Masc. Pl.	**ATR:** the same verb used of the gospel in v.6, now active of the believers. **Significance:** The fruitful gospel produces fruitful people.
v.11	**δυναμόω** *strengthened*	**G1412** *dynamoō* Pres. Pass. Ptc. Nom. Masc. Pl.	**THAY:** to make strong, to enable. **Significance:** Present and passive: a continuous supply of strength from God, measured by "His glorious might."
v.11	**ὑπομονή** *steadfastness*	**G5281** *hypomonē* Acc. Fem. Sg.	**VINE:** literally "an abiding under"; endurance under trial. **THAY:** steadfastness that is not swerved from its purpose by trials.

Verse	Greek Word (Lexical Form) / English	Strong's # / Transliteration / Form	Definition & Significance
			Significance: Endurance chiefly toward circumstances: holding up under pressure.
v.11	**μακροθυμία** *patience*	**G3115** *makrothymia* Acc. Fem. Sg.	**VINE:** long-suffering; self-restraint that does not hastily retaliate. **Significance:** Patience chiefly toward people who provoke us.
v.12	**ἱκανόω** *qualified*	**G2427** *hikanoō* Aor. Act. Ptc. Dat. Masc. Sg.	**STR:** to make sufficient, render fit. **ATR:** aorist: a completed act of the Father. **Significance:** The Father, not the believer, supplied the qualification; it is already done.
v.13	**ῥύομαι** *rescued*	**G4506** *rhyomai* Aor. Mid. Ind. 3rd Sg.	**THAY:** to draw to oneself, to rescue, deliver. **Significance:** God drew us out of Satan's domain to Himself; a decisive past rescue.
v.13	**μεθίστημι** *transferred*	**G3179** *methistēmi* Aor. Act. Ind. 3rd Sg.	**MRV:** used of removing a people from one land and settling them in another. **Significance:** Believers have a new realm and a new King: the kingdom of the beloved Son.
v.14	**ἀπολύτρωσις** *redemption*	**G629** *apolytrōsis* Acc. Fem. Sg.	**VINE:** release effected by payment of a ransom. **THAY:** deliverance procured by the payment of a price. **Significance:** Christ paid the price; "we have" redemption now, a present possession.
v.14	**ἄφεσις** *forgiveness*	**G859** *aphesis* Acc. Fem. Sg.	**STR:** freedom, pardon; a sending away. **Significance:** Redemption results in sins sent away; forgiveness is complete, not partial.

Grammar key — Cases: Nom. · Gen. · Dat. · Acc. · Voc. | Number: Sg. · Pl. | Gender: Masc. · Fem. · Neut. Verb Mood: Ind. · Imp. · Subj. · Opt. · Inf. · Ptc. | Tense: Pres. · Imperf. · Fut. · Aor. · Perf. · Plpf. | Voice: Act. · Mid. · Pass. | Person: 1st/2nd/3rd Sg./Pl.

Study Questions

Part 1 — From the Commentary

Review prompt	From the commentary
What three parts of a building picture this prayer?	Foundation (knowledge), superstructure (a worthy walk), and the outer part people see (fruit, growth, power, thanksgiving).
How do knowledge, wisdom, and understanding differ?	Knowledge is full and accurate; wisdom applies it to life; understanding brings truths together and exposes error.
What is God's power for, according to verse 11?	Not for show but for go: steadfastness (with circumstances) and patience (with people), with joy.
What four things has the Father done (vv.12–14)?	Qualified us, rescued us, transferred us, and redeemed us (forgiveness of sins).

Review prompt	From the commentary
How is a worthy walk related to salvation?	It is the fitting response of people already saved, not the price of eternal life.

Part 2 — Study Questions

1. Why does Paul pray for "knowledge" (*epignōsis*) rather than simply warning against false teaching?

> **Leader's answer:** The best defense against counterfeit knowledge is full, accurate knowledge of God's will. The false teachers boasted of *gnōsis*; Paul prays the Colossians will be "filled" with true knowledge, joined with spiritual wisdom and understanding to discern and refute error.

2. How does Paul become part of the answer to his own prayer, and what does that suggest for us?

> **Leader's answer:** He prays for their knowledge and then writes the letter that supplies it. Like the picture of giving bread to a hungry neighbor rather than only praying for him, we should be ready to be used in answering our prayers for others.

3. Distinguish "steadfastness" from "patience" in verse 11.

> **Leader's answer:** Steadfastness (*hypomonē*, "remaining under") is endurance under trying circumstances; patience (*makrothymia*, "long-tempered") is restraint toward provoking people. God's power supplies both, and with joy.

4. What does "qualified" (v.12) teach about the believer's fitness for the inheritance?

> **Leader's answer:** The Father did the qualifying, and the aorist marks it as done. Believers are made fit by God, not by their own performance, so the worthy walk flows from acceptance rather than seeking it.

5. What does the word "transferred" picture, and how should it change the way a believer sees himself?

> **Leader's answer:** It was used of relocating a population to a new land. Believers have been removed from the domain of darkness and settled in the kingdom of the beloved Son: a new realm, a new King, a new identity.

Part 3 — Passage Summary

Verses	Theme	Key truth
1:9	The foundation	Paul prays unceasingly that they be filled with full knowledge of God's will, with spiritual wisdom and understanding.
1:10a	The superstructure	Knowledge leads to a walk worthy of the Lord, pleasing Him in every respect.
1:10b–11	The outer part	Fruit in every good work, growth in knowledge, and power for endurance and patience with joy.
1:12–14	The thanksgiving	The Father qualified, rescued, transferred, and redeemed us; we have forgiveness of sins.

⑤ APPLICATION

Closes the study · personal and corporate

1. Upgrade Your Prayer List

Scripture anchor: Colossians 1:9–10

Source: Draws from ③ Commentary, I and II, and ② Devotional

Paul prayed for spiritual knowledge, a worthy walk, and fruitful lives. Our prayers for one another often stop at circumstances. There is nothing wrong with praying about health and needs, but Paul shows us how to aim higher: that people we love would know God's will and live in a way that pleases Him.

Reflection: Whom do you pray for regularly? What would it look like to pray Colossians 1:9–12 over them?

Practical step: Choose three people and pray verses 9–12 for them by name every day this week.

2. Be the Bread

Scripture anchor: Colossians 1:9; 4:16

Source: Draws from ③ Commentary, I.C

Paul prayed and then supplied what he prayed for. When God puts a need on your heart in prayer, ask whether He may want to use you to meet it. A phone call, a meal, a Bible passage shared at the right time, or a simple word of encouragement may be God's answer through you.

Reflection: Is there a prayer you have prayed for someone that you could help answer yourself?

Practical step: Act on one prayer this week by doing something practical for the person you have been praying for.

3. Power for Endurance and Patience

Scripture anchor: Colossians 1:11

Source: Draws from ③ Commentary, III.C, and ④ Study Question 3

God supplies strength according to His glorious might, not according to our weakness. That strength is aimed at two places where we often fail: hard circumstances that tempt us to give up, and hard people who tempt us to strike back. Ask for power specifically for these, and expect joy to accompany it.

Reflection: Which is harder for you right now: a circumstance you must endure, or a person you must be patient with?

Practical step: Write down that circumstance or person, and pray verse 11 over it each morning this week.

4. Give Thanks for What Is Already Done

Scripture anchor: Colossians 1:12–14

Source: Draws from ③ Commentary, III.D; cf. Bing, Simply by Grace (FGR)

Every verb in verses 12–14 describes something the Father has already done. Believers do not work to become qualified, rescued, or forgiven; they give thanks that they are. Free Grace teachers like Charles Bing remind us that assurance rests on God's finished work, and that assurance becomes the soil in which a grateful, worthy walk grows.

Reflection: Do you tend to live as though you are still trying to earn God's acceptance?

Practical step: Read verses 12–14 aloud each day this week and thank God for each of the four gifts by name.

End of Study · Colossians 1:9–14